



[OGS \(HTTPS://INTERNATIONAL.NORTHEASTERN.EDU/OGS\)](https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs)



Students Studying in The United States

APPLYING FOR THE F-1 STEM OPT EXTENSION



F-1 students who receive Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics (STEM) degrees and meet the requirements below may be eligible to apply for a 24-month extension of their Post-Completion Optional Practical Training (OPT).

RECENT USCIS POLICY UPDATES

Last Updated January 30, 2026 (<https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/uscis-policy-changes/>)

WHAT IS THE STEM OPT EXTENSION?

The 24-month STEM OPT Extension is a type of employment authorization adjudicated by U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS). It is available to eligible F-1 students for the purpose of gaining practical experience directly related to their program of study. A STEM Extension application requires a student to be on an approved period of Post-Completion OPT, to have an E-verify employer that provides a student with formal training and learning, a STEM OPT recommendation on the Form I-20, then a timely application to USCIS for final adjudication. If successful, USCIS will issue an Employment Authorization Document (EAD) granting the student 24-months of work authorization.

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ELIGIBILITY

To be eligible for the 24-month STEM OPT Extension you must meet all of the following requirements:

1. Be maintaining F-1 status
2. Be on an authorized period of Post-Completion OPT
3. Have earned a bachelor's, master's, or PhD (certificate programs are not eligible) degree within the last 10 years in an eligible [STEM field](#)
(<https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/stem-opt-hub/additional-resources/eligible-cip-codes-for-the-stem-opt-extension>) as listed on the [DHS STEM Designated Program List](#)
(<https://www.ice.gov/doclib/sevis/pdf/stemList2024.pdf>) (from a SEVP-certified school that is accredited when the student submits their STEM OPT extension application to USCIS)

➤ See below for more details about how to find out if your degree is STEM designated
4. Have an offer of employment from an employer that is enrolled in the [U.S. Government's E-Verify program](#).
(<https://www.e-verify.gov/>)
5. Work in a position directly related to your STEM program

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major as listed on your Form I-20

6. Work a minimum of 20-hours per week per employer
7. Not be self-employed
8. Be employed in a paid position as a W-2 employee
 - > You must be paid at the same level as “similarly situated” ([https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/stem-opt-hub/for-employers/employers-and-the-form-i-983#:~:text=The%20term%20%E2%80%9Csimilarly,area%20of%20employment.\)](https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/stem-opt-hub/for-employers/employers-and-the-form-i-983#:~:text=The%20term%20%E2%80%9Csimilarly,area%20of%20employment.)))” U.S. workers in comparable positions.
 - > STEM OPT participants must work in positions that provide structured, supervised training experiences as W-2 employees. Northeastern University does not authorize STEM OPT for employment arrangements that classify F-1 alumni as independent contractors or 1099 workers. Alumni seeking STEM OPT authorization should ensure they will be hired as employees with direct employer supervision and as W-2 employees.

To be eligible for the STEM OPT Extension, your employer must:

1. Be enrolled in the U.S. Government’s E-Verify program (<https://www.e-verify.gov/>)
2. Have a federal EIN
3. Agree to all terms of the STEM OPT Extension by completing the required sections of the Form I-983 (<https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/stem-opt-hub/additional-resources/form-i-983-overview>)
4. Hire you as a W-2 employee
5. Be prepared for possible employer site visits (<https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/stem-opt-hub/for-employers/employer-site-visits>)

STEM Designated Degrees

To verify STEM eligibility, look at the code listed under “Primary Major” on Page 1 of your I-20 and compare that code in the Classification of Instructional Programs (CIP) column of the U.S. Department of Homeland Security STEM Designated Degree Programs

(<https://www.ice.gov/doclib/sevis/pdf/stemList2024.pdf>) list. If your major code is on the list, then it is considered to be STEM eligible.

You can learn more about [CIP Codes and the CIP Code assignment process at Northeastern University here](#). (https://service.northeastern.edu/registrar?id=kb_article_view&sysparm_article=KB000019876&sys_kb_id=1380e9fe33f15ed0069dd1355d5c7b5c#mcetoc_1icm7ch17j5).

Please note: the DHS STEM Designated Degree Programs list was recently **updated on July 22, 2024**. Please be sure you are accessing the most recent STEM list linked above, which can also be found on the U.S. Immigrations and Customs Enforcement website on [this page](#) (<https://www.ice.gov/sevis/schools>) in the “Resources” section under the “DHS STEM Designated Degree Program List and CIP Code Nomination Process” tab. No students at Northeastern University were impacted by the update.

Important Note for Alumni with an Approved Cap-Gap Extension

F-1 alumni with an approved Cap-Gap Extension may be eligible to apply for the STEM OPT Extension as long as USCIS receives their application before the expiration of their Post-OPT EAD. **However, if your Post-OPT EAD end date is already in the past (even if you have received a Cap-Gap Extension), an application for the STEM OPT Extension is likely to be denied by USCIS.**

Please [review the information on the H-1B and the Cap-Gap Extension page](#) (<https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/employment/working-after-graduation/cap-gap-extension/#:~:text=CAN%20I%20APPLY%20FOR%20THE%20STEM%20EXTENSION%20DURING%20THE%20CAP%20GAP%20EXTENSION%20PERIOD%3F>) of our website for more details.

STEM EXTENSION APPLICATION TIMELINE

Students may apply to USCIS for the STEM OPT Extension work authorization no earlier than 90 days prior to the Post-OPT EAD expiration date.

Completed applications **must be received by USCIS within 60 days of the STEM OPT recommendation date and prior to the expiration date on the Post-Completion OPT**

EAD to be properly (timely) filed. USCIS will not accept applications for the STEM Extension that are received beyond the expiration date of the Post-OPT EAD.

Students must also be **inside the U.S. when submitting their application to USCIS.**

COMPLETING THE FORM I-983 WITH YOUR EMPLOYER

All students must submit a [completed Form I-983](https://www.ice.gov/doclib/sevis/pdf/i983.pdf) (<https://www.ice.gov/doclib/sevis/pdf/i983.pdf>) to OGS in order to receive the STEM OPT Extension recommendation on their Form I-20. Students should reference the official [USCIS Instructions of the Form I-983](https://www.ice.gov/doclib/sevis/pdf/i983Instructions.pdf) (<https://www.ice.gov/doclib/sevis/pdf/i983Instructions.pdf>) and the [resources available on the Study in the States website](https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/stem-opt-hub/additional-resources/form-i-983-overview) (<https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/stem-opt-hub/additional-resources/form-i-983-overview>) as they complete the I-983.

Additionally, OGS has prepared a supplemental guide to filling out the Form I-983 to assist students as they complete their application for the STEM OPT Extension. Because the STEM OPT Extension application is a personal petition to USCIS, OGS is unable to advise on how to complete each section of the form. However, this guide offers clarification on some of the I-983 instructions provided by USCIS.

Please Note: All fields on the Form I-983 must be completed in full when you submit your STEM Extension request to OGS. This resource does not provide guidance on how to complete every field of every section of the I-983; rather, it has been created to help guide students through the most frequently questioned sections.

FORM I-983 SUPPLEMENTAL GUIDE

Please first review USCIS' I-983 instructions that are linked in the section above. Then, you may use this supplemental guide for additional clarity if needed.

+ Section 1: Student Information (completed by student):

+ Section 2: Student Certification (completed by student):

+ Section 3: Employer Information (completed by employer):

+ Section 4: Employer Certification (completed by employer):

+ Section 5: Training Plan for STEM OPT Students (completed by student and employer):

+ Section 6: Employer Official Certification (completed by employer):

+ Evaluation on Student Progress (completed by student and employer):

OGS AND USCIS APPLICATION PROCESS

(For more information, click each step below)

+ Step 1: Pay the STEM OPT Administrative Fee

+ Step 2: Submit the STEM Extension I-20 Request to OGS

+ Step 3: Prepare your STEM OPT Extension Application for USCIS

+ Step 4: (Optional) Premium Processing

+ Step 5: Attend a Biometrics Appointment (if scheduled)

+ Prepare for a USCIS Review of Publicly Available Social Media

AFTER YOU SUBMIT TO USCIS

Remember, as long as you timely filed your application with USCIS, you may continue working for up to 180 days (6 months) while your application is pending!*

+ Receipt Notice (Form I-797) and Waiting Period*

+ Premium Processing

+ Changing Employers while Your Application is Pending

+ Do Not Travel While Your Application is Pending

APPLICATION OUTCOMES

+ **STEM OPT is Approved**

+ **Received a Request for Evidence (RFE) , Notice of Intent to Deny (NOID), or Notice of Intent to Revoke (NOIR)**

+ **STEM OPT Denied**

RESOLVING COMMON OPT AND STEM APPLICATION AND EAD ISSUES

Problems or Issues with your OPT/STEM OPT application or EAD card(s)? Check out our knowledge base article on how to resolve common OPT/STEM OPT application and EAD card issues.

[Click Here \(https://northeastern.service-now.com/kb_view.do?sysparm_article=KB000023648\)](https://northeastern.service-now.com/kb_view.do?sysparm_article=KB000023648)

IMPORTANT REMINDERS

- > Do not submit STEM OPT application to USCIS before receiving the STEM OPT recommendation on your I-20
- > USCIS must receive the STEM OPT application within **60 days** of the STEM OPT recommendation made by OGS; if the application is not received by USCIS within 60 days after the issuance of STEM OPT recommendation, the application will be denied

- > You must comply with all [reporting requirements while on the STEM OPT Extension](https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/employment/working-after-graduation/reporting-stem-opt/)
(<https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/employment/working-after-graduation/reporting-stem-opt/>)

Exceeding Unemployment during the STEM Extension

If you accrue more than the aggregate limit of 150 days of unemployment during your Post-OPT and STEM Extension periods, your SEVIS record may be automatically terminated. It is your responsibility to appropriately report all employment to OGS.

RESPONSIBILITIES DURING THE STEM OPT EXTENSION

+ **Reporting Employment during STEM OPT**

+ **Traveling During STEM OPT**

+ **Studying During STEM OPT**

RELATED ARTICLES:

Reporting STEM OPT Extension (F-1)

(<https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/employment/working-after-graduation/reporting-stem-opt/>)

Form I-983 Supplemental Guide

(<https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/employment/working-after-graduation/24-stem-opt/form-i-983-supplemental-guide/>)

Form I-765 Supplemental Guide

(<https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/employment/off-campus-employment/form-i-765->

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Monday-Friday: 8:30a.m.-5:00p.m.
(Note: We are closed on Tuesdays from 3:00pm – 4:00pm for all staff training and meeting).

Phone Hours:
Monday-Friday: 8:30a.m.-4:30p.m. ET

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